

Cards and Community: Social Connection in (the) Flesh and Blood

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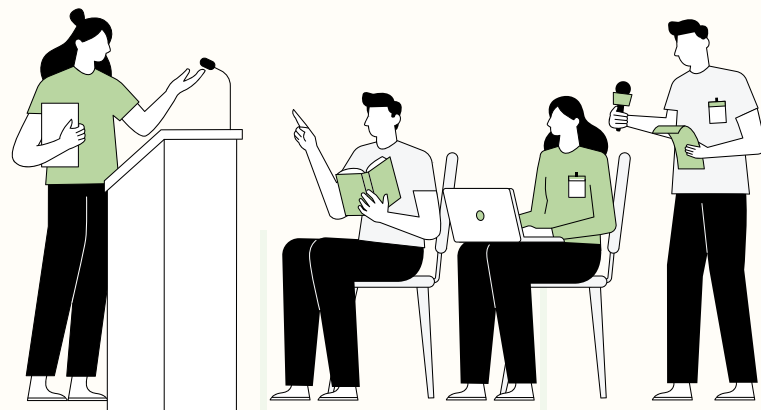
21.06.2025





✦ AGENDA ✦

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WHAT IS FLESH AND BLOOD?

A competitive collectible card game (TCG)

  In-person only (no digital version)

 Emphasis on local events & travel

 Strategic, deck-building focused



STUDY OVERVIEW

STUDY MOTIVATION



- Community-building in analog games
- Neurodivergent inclusion & structured social spaces
- Post-pandemic shifts in social gaming

✦ METHOD ✦



Survey Design

- Anonymous Google Form
- Mix of multiple-choice & open-ended questions



Key Topics

- Emotional impact of playing
- Friendship and community building
- Motivation for in-person events
- Neurodivergence self-identification



Incentive

- 6 random respondents received a special Flesh and Blood card as a thank-you

SURVEY OVERVIEW



Exploratory survey



May–June 2025



36 participants (via FaB
whatsapp chats)



Mixed quantitative and qualitative
questions

DEMOGRAPHICS



Average Age: 30.8 (Range: 18–51)

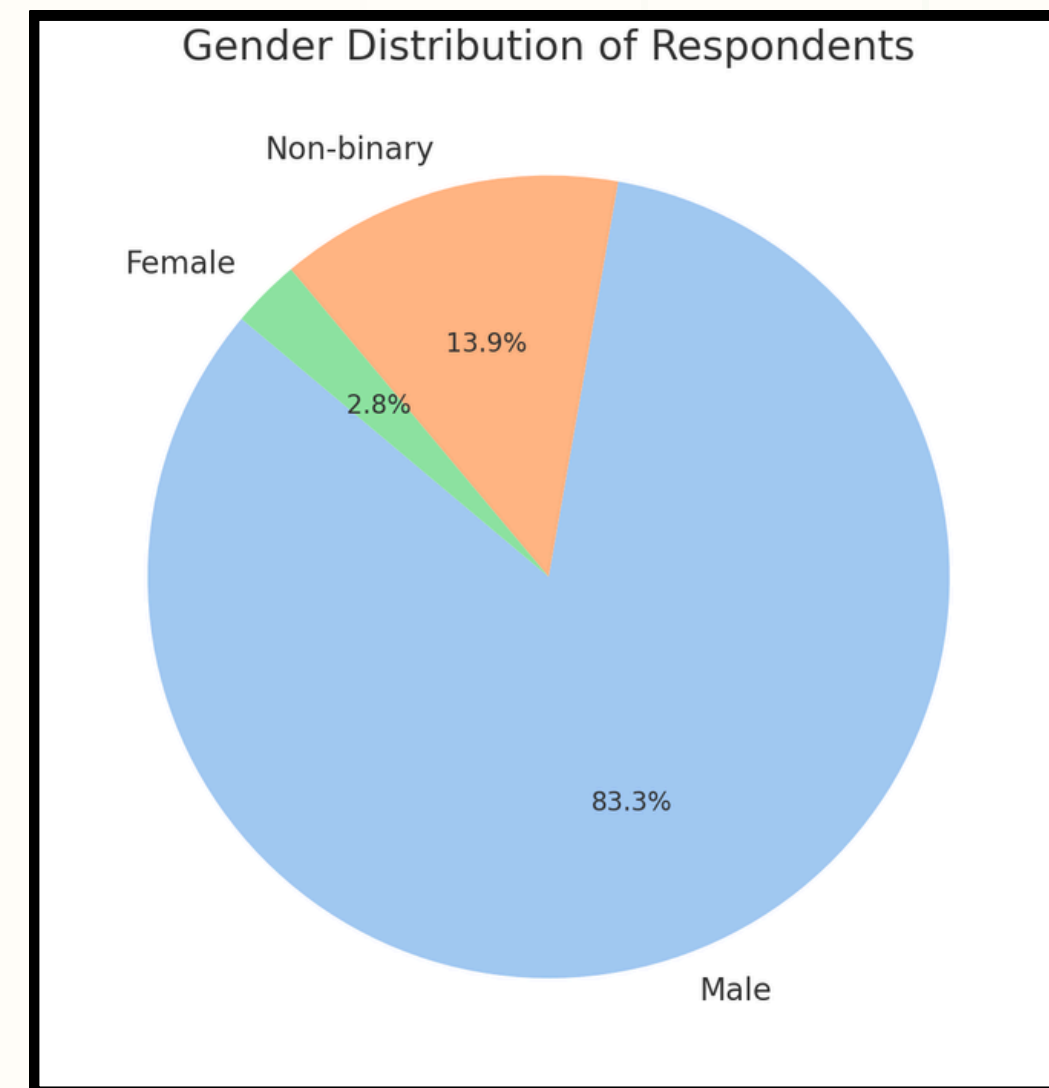


Most Common Countries: Austria (26), Spain (8), Germany (1), Catalonia (1)

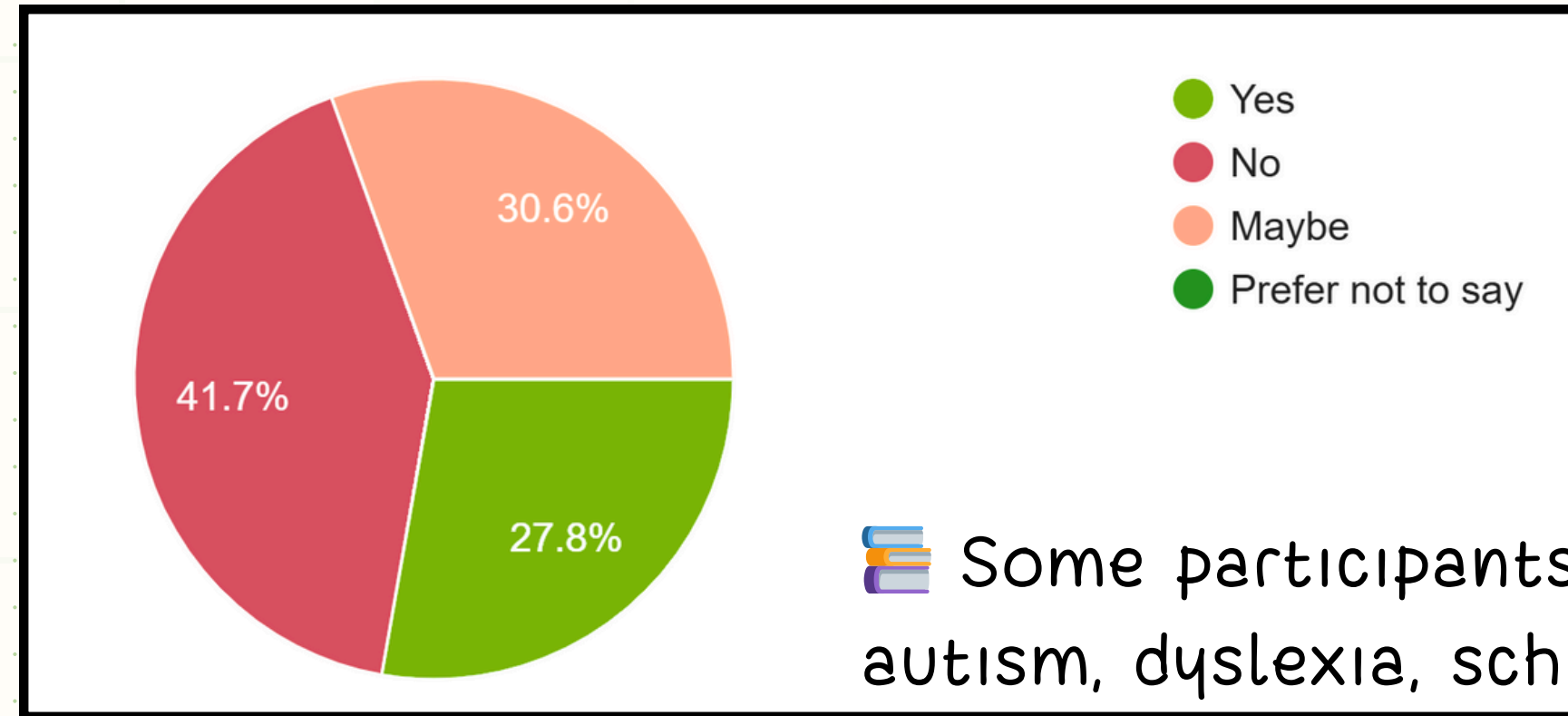


Gender Distribution

Gender diversity was present, but most respondents identified as male



✦ NEURODIVERGENCE SELF-IDENTIFICATION ✦



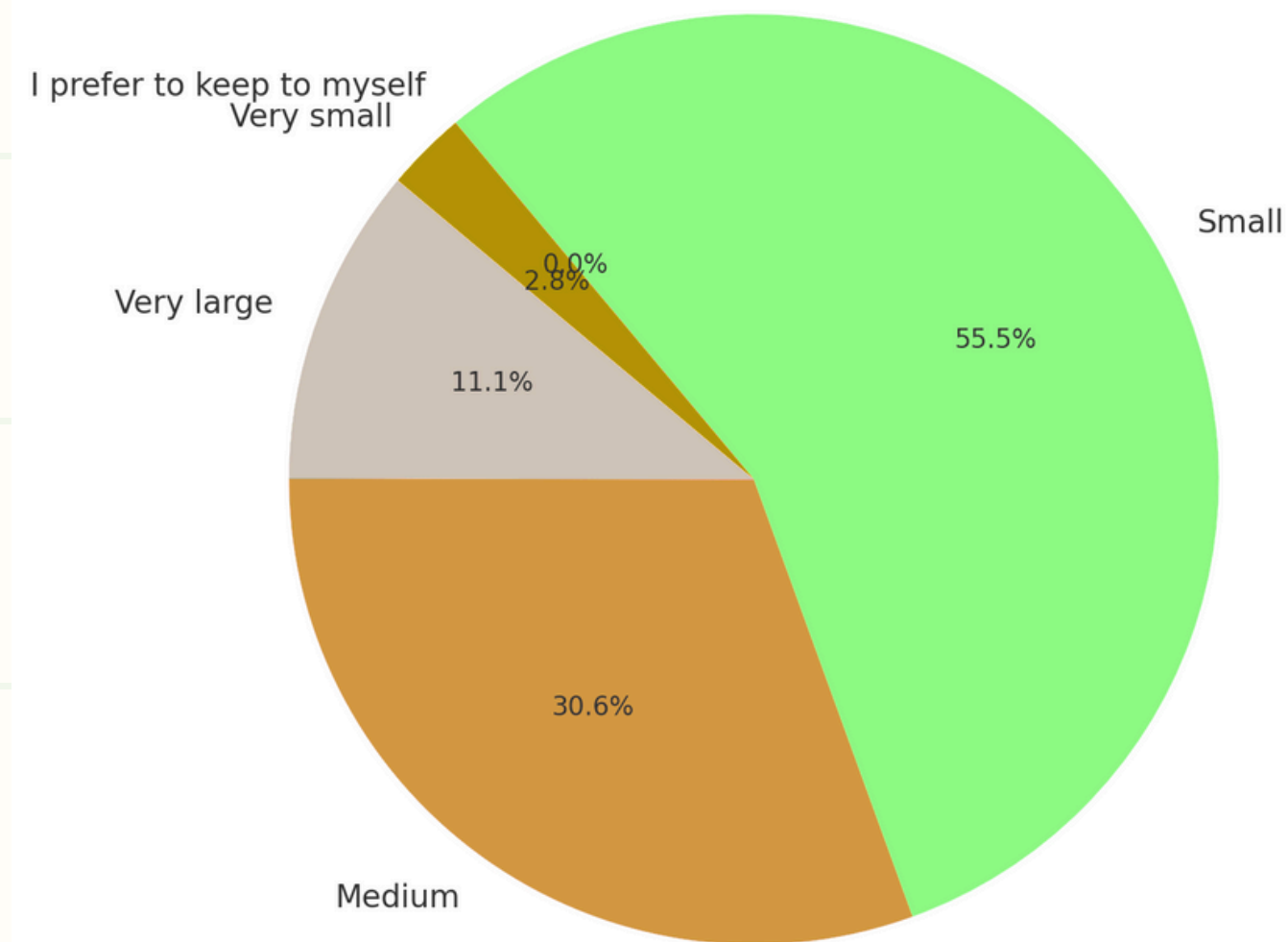
📖 Some participants mentioned formal diagnoses (ADHD, autism, dyslexia, schizoaffective disorder, Tourette's), while others are still exploring or awaiting diagnosis.

🌀 Many responses included uncertainty ("maybe," "still figuring it out," "not sure")

💬 ADHD and autism were the most frequently self-identified or suspected forms of neurodivergence.

😞 A few participants also mentioned chronic depression, anxiety, or schizophrenia alongside neurodivergent identities.

✧ SOCIAL CIRCLE ✧



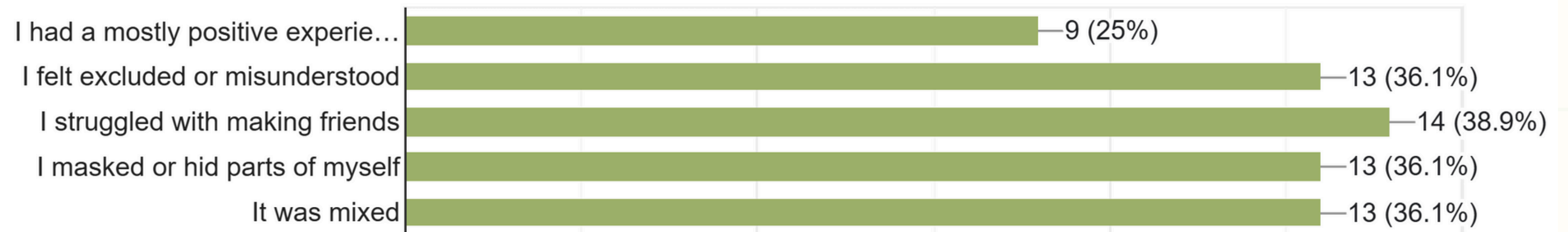
- 🔄 Many participants mentioned changes in their social life due to moves, life transitions, or distance.
- 👤 ♀ Most maintain a few close friendships, prioritizing deeper connections over large networks.
- 📺 For several participants, their fab group is the main or only active circle.
- 🌐 Social ties often span offline, online, and hobby-based communities.
- 😞 Some mentioned introversion, difficulty making friends, or social fatigue.

FRIENDSHIP HABITS

How do you usually form friendships?

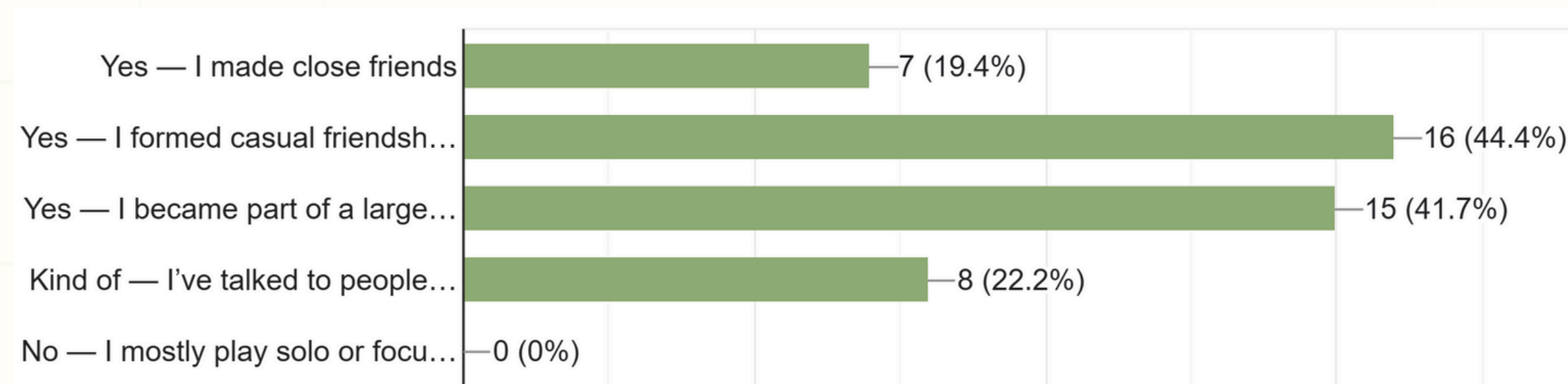
-  Through hobbies or games – 28 out of 36 (77.8%)
-  At school or work – 18 out of 36 (50%)
-  I find it difficult to make friends – 11 out of 36 (30.6%)

REFLECTIONS ON EARLY SOCIAL EXPERIENCES



- 📌 Only 25% of participants described their school years as mostly positive without qualifiers.
- 👁️ **The majority had mixed or difficult social experiences, with many expressing feelings of exclusion or disconnect.**
- 😬 36% said they **masked** or hid parts of themselves to fit in.
- 😬 40% **struggled with making friends** during school.
- 💔 Some shared experiences of bullying

✦ SOCIAL IMPACT OF PLAYING ✦ FLESH AND BLOOD



Have you made new friends or meaningful connections through FaB?

- 🤝 Casual friendships or local connections – mentioned by 44% of participants
- 🌐 Became part of a larger community – mentioned by 41% of participants
- ❤️ Made close friends – mentioned by 19 participants
- 👥 Some connection, but no lasting contact – mentioned by 22% of participants

✦ FAB TRAVELLING ✦

✈️ 58.3% of respondents have traveled outside their region to attend a FaB event. Out of these:

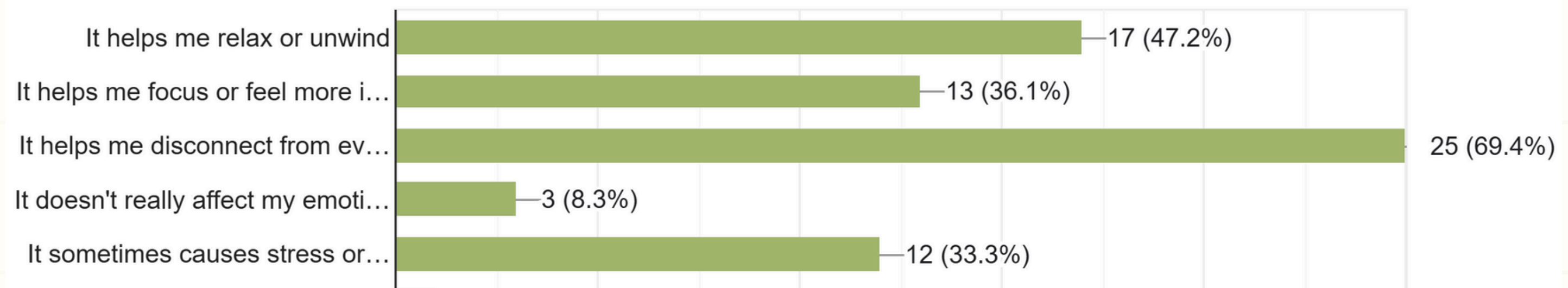
- 17% made **new friends** or joined new communities through travel
- 39% had **some social contact** while traveling, but didn't stay in touch

FAVORITE TRAVEL MOMENTS

- 🗣️ "I love using different languages during matches — and people come up to me because they recognize me from previous events."
- 🚗 "The drives to the events are usually very fun... hearing about people's pasts was really memorable."
- 🌍 "Last year I went to Osaka for Worlds — met people from around the globe, shared an apartment with a player I'd met before."
 - 💬 "Carpooling and lunch after tournaments always makes me feel more connected."
 - ❤️ "My first large TCG event — Worlds in Barcelona — it was everything I hoped it would be."

✦ EMOTIONAL IMPACT ✦

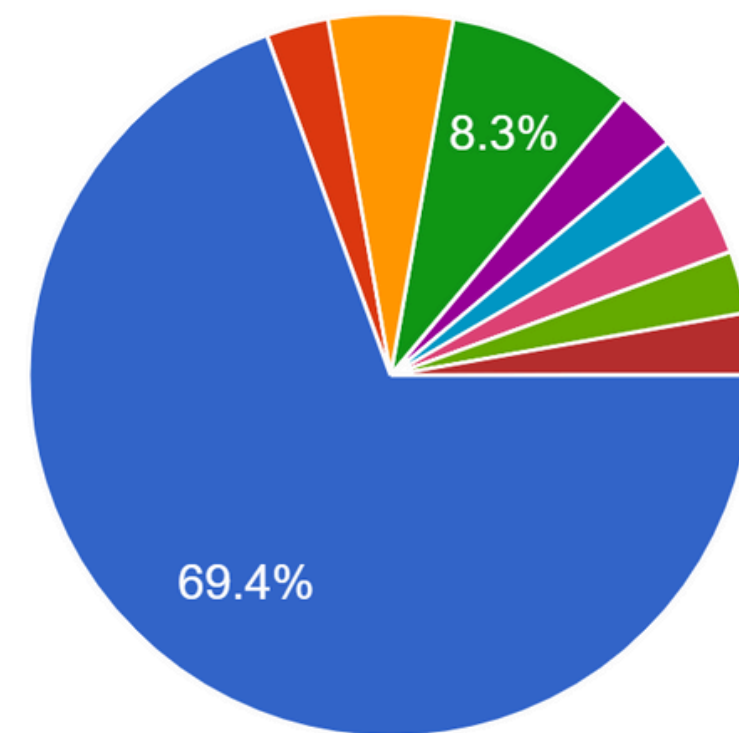
- 🎯 Most respondents (70%) use faB as a way to **disconnect** from everyday worries.
- 🧘 Half of the respondents say the game helps them **relax** or unwind.
- 🧩 36% report feeling more **focused** or in control while playing.
- 😓 However, 42% also said that faB sometimes causes **stress** or anxiety.
 - However, one participant noted that this stress can feel positive or motivating, unlike work stress.



Importantly, no one reported strongly negative emotional impact overall. Even those who feel occasional stress also cited positive aspects.

SOCIAL ENCOURAGEMENT IN FAB

🌱 **25 participants (70%) said FaB's in-person format encourages them to connect with others more than other games.**



- Yes — the in-person format helps me connect with people
- Kind of — I like the community, but I'd...
- Not really — I would prefer to play onli...
- I haven't played many other games
- Regarding TCGs, I don't think fab enc...
- Same way as other TCG's
- No, I feel the community we have doe...
- The community seems more open an...
- I don't see a strong difference. But to...

✧ PERSONAL REFLECTIONS ON FLESH AND BLOOD ✧

"It has pretty much changed my life — I've made lots of friends, traveled to many different countries, and it helped me a lot through hard times"

"Even if I'd consider it to be a minimal part of my life, it's always a safe and known place to go back to. And all of it because of the people that are a part of it."

"I'd still rather play online if there was ranked... it's a weird dynamic — if I win I'm happy and they're upset, and if I lose I'm upset and they're happy."

MAIN FINDINGS

Neurodivergent Participation

~1/3 of respondents identified as neurodivergent (ND).

Structured Interaction

Clear rules and shared focus ease social anxiety

Positive Social Outcomes

Most ND players reported increased connection and community

Games as Safe Spaces

faB supports "socializing with a script" through structured play



IMPLICATIONS: DESIGNING ND-FRIENDLY GAME COMMUNITIES

Clear Etiquette & Roles

Structured rules ease interaction and reduce ambiguity

Special Interest Pathways

Shared lore & strategy support meaningful connection

Community Moderation Matters

A zero-tolerance, proactive ethos creates safety

✦ BROADER IMPLICATIONS: FAB & THE VALUE OF “THIRD PLACES” ✦

- Game stores as community hubs
- FaB events often act as welcoming third spaces beyond home or work
- Combating loneliness post-pandemic
- Structured play fosters routine, social connection, and shared purpose
- Design insight for planners & policymakers
- Supporting hobby venues = low-cost path to community well-being

✧ BROADER IMPLICATIONS FOR GAME STUDIES ✧

Games as social instruments

faB is more than “fun”—it fosters real-world social bonds across ages & professions.

Affinity groups & culture-building

The community forms a distinct lexicon and shared identity—like other game subcultures.

Analog vs. Digital

Physical play enables co-presence, spontaneity, and embodied interaction that digital play often can't match.

✦ BROADER IMPLICATIONS: ✦ COMMUNITY DESIGN

Consistency builds connection

Weekly events create ritual and foster real friendships.

Clear goals & social norms

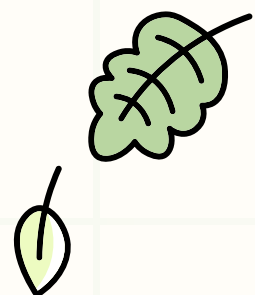
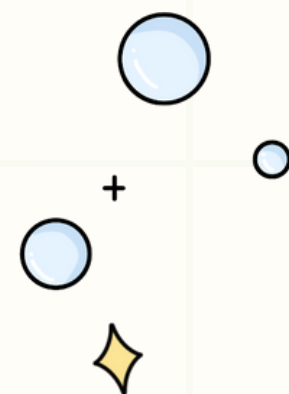
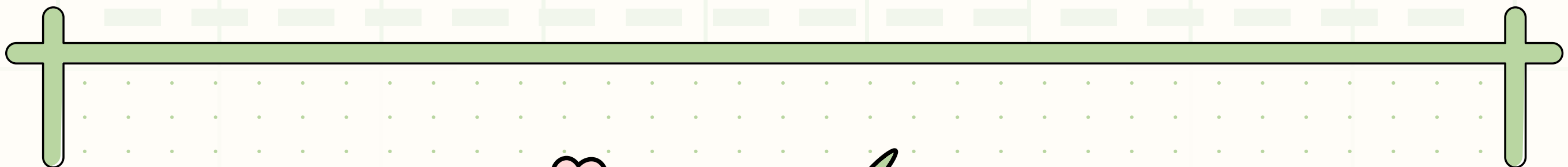
Shared focus, respectful conduct, and structured etiquette reduce ambiguity.

Inclusivity through moderation

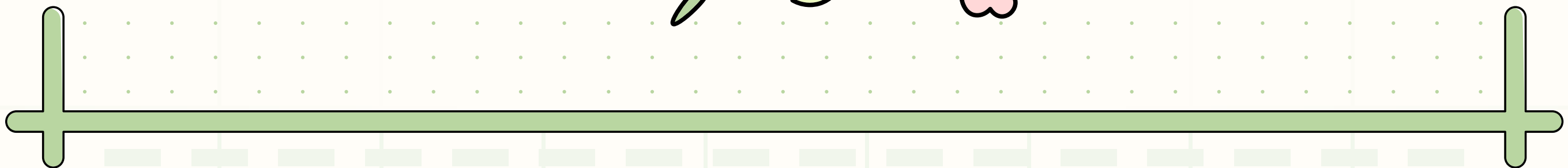
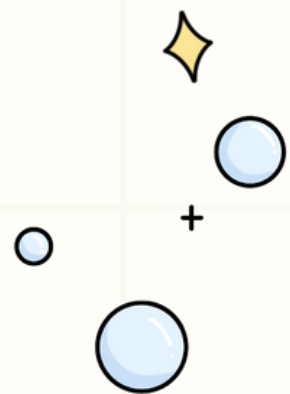
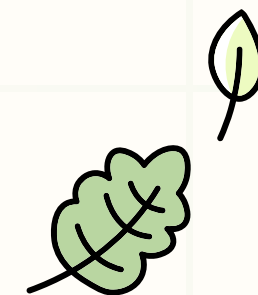
Leaders help shape culture—cooperation over pure competition.

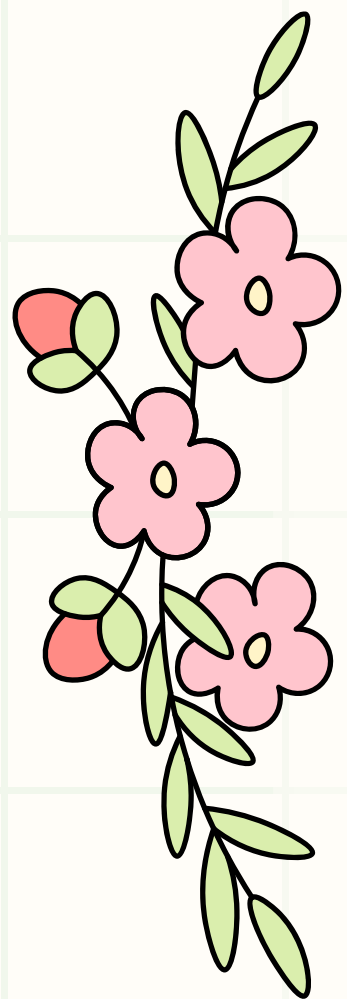
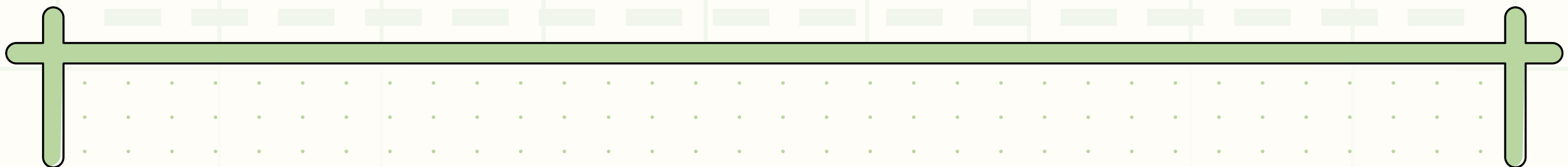
Open question

Can faB scale without losing its community feel?



Q & A





THANK
YOU

